

LOST MOUNTAIN

PART TWO

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INTRODUCTION



WHITEWASH IN MARTIN CO

Deals with the aftermath
of the Martin Co. coal
slurry spill, one of the
worst environmental
disasters in the south



JUNE 2004

Deals with the
reintroduction of Elk in
Eastern Kentucky and
strip mining and its
effects



JULY 2004

Case study



01

**WHITEWASH IN
MARTIN COUNTY**

THE DISASTER

- October 20, 2000: Martin County Coal slurry breached
- Owned by Massey Energy
- 300 million gallons of toxic slurry released
- Flooded streams, killed aquatic life, and contaminated drinking water



THE “WHITEWASH”



- Disaster was systematically downplayed by multiple parties
- Massey energy minimized its responsibility
- State regulators failed to hold the company accountable
- Only minimal fines were issued and no criminal charges were filed
- Reece compares it to Exxon Valdez – which drew massive national attention

COMMUNITY IMPACT

- Residents were left without drinking water
- Rural Appalachian communities are economically dependent on coal
- Economic dependence limits political power to fight back
- Low-income communities bear the heaviest burden of environmental harm



BROADER THEMES



- Coal companies, regulators, and politicians operate in collusion
- Environmental destruction in Appalachia is made invisible to the rest of the country
- Appalachian communities are treated as expendable
- Part of Reece's larger body of work exposing systemic neglect in the region

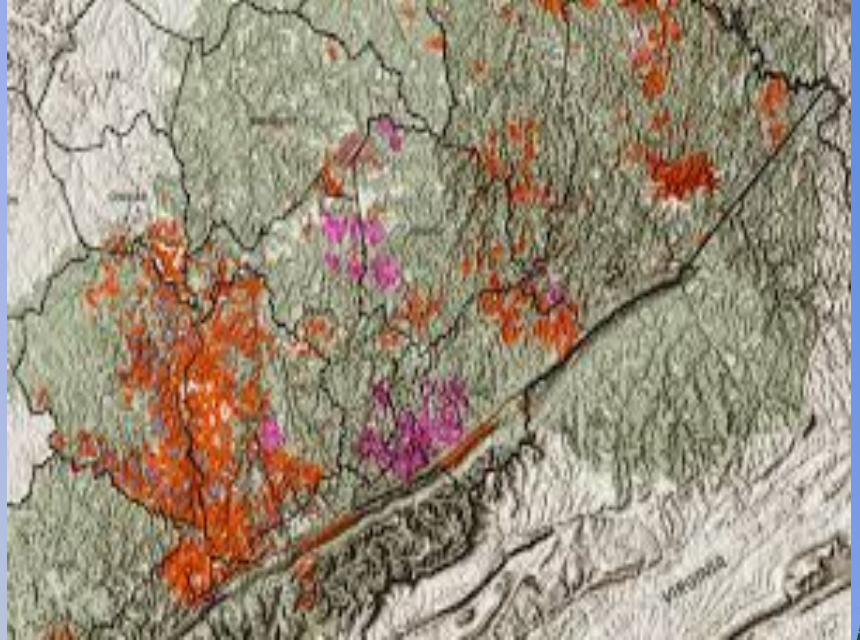
02

JUNE, 2004



ELK REINTRODUCTION IN EASTERN KENTUCKY

- Elk hunted to extinction in 1867
- 1,500 Elk reintroduced in late 1990's
- Elk calves are vulnerable to disease
- "only 35 percent of reclaimed land can support fish and wildlife."
- There are now over 5,000 Elk in the region, showing that the reintroduction was successful.



COAL MINING AND THE ENVIRONMENTAL CONFLICT

- Conflicts include erosion, silt buildups, and health problems.
- "Found that in 60 percent of the cases, the bond money was not adequate to complete the reclamation."
- This is an extremely complicated topic because the same industry that damages the land also supports local livelihoods.



03

JULY, 2004



CASE STUDY: PATSY CARTER

- Grew up in the Appalachian with rowboats as main means of transportation
- Illegal coal trafficking spike 21st century
- Immediate family devastation

KAHOOT!

<https://create.kahoot.it/details/98fba3e4-5ef0-42c5-98b2-bef710dbf3f4?drawer=>

REVIEW QUESTIONS

Because key words are great for catching your
audience's attention

REVIEW QUESTIONS

Reece argues that economic dependence on coal effectively silences Appalachian communities even when they are being harmed. Do you think that silence is a choice, or is it a form of coercion? What would it take for a community in that position to find its voice?

Regulators acknowledged the disaster, fines were issued, reports were filed – yet no one went to jail and the system that allowed the spill largely remained intact. Is that a failure of law, of politics, or of public will? What would genuine accountability have looked like in Martin County?



REVIEW QUESTIONS

Reece suggests that Appalachian land and people have long been treated as expendable – a “sacrifice zone” where environmental and human costs are accepted so that the rest of the country can benefit from cheap energy. Do you agree with that framing? And if so, what moral obligation, if any, do energy consumers outside the region bear for what happens there?

How does the story of the Huntley-Brinkley Road show the difference between why people originally built it and what it became under heavy coal hauling?



REVIEW QUESTIONS

What does the chapter reveal about how overloaded coal trucks affect not just roads, but individuals, families, and whole communities?

Why do you think the state's attempt to enforce weight limits and fix the problem ended up changing very little in the end?

